

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Vote on budget amendment put off

Prolongs doubt on funding source for new teachers contract, pension payment

By Nell Salzman and Alice Yin
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago Board of Education on Thursday postponed a controversial budget amendment pushed by Mayor Brandon Johnson, prolonging doubt about who will pay for a new teachers contract and a \$175 million pension payment to the city.

That means the latter's cost remains on the city's side. The city has until the end of this month to either resolve the budget gap or end the 2024 fiscal year with a deficit.

Just minutes before its monthly meeting, the school board called off the votes that would pave the way for Chicago Public Schools to issue or repurpose \$242 million in debt and ink an agreement making the district responsible for its pension obligation. School board President Sean Harden cited contract negotiations as the reason for the delay.

"We're extremely, extremely close to settling the teachers union contract," Harden said at the start of Thursday's board meeting.

He did not specify when the budget amendment would go up for a vote.

According to several sources close to contract negotiations, Chicago Teachers Union President Stacy Davis Gates led a strong push for a new four-year contract to be settled Thursday before the board meeting where members were supposed to vote on the amendment. It needed 14 votes from board members to pass.

The ongoing battle over finances and borrowing in the nation's fourth-largest school district has put immense pressure on the board in recent weeks. The canceled vote is the latest twist in the dramatic, long-running power struggle between Johnson and his lame-duck CPS CEO, Pedro

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Chicago Public Schools board President Sean Harden leads a meeting Thursday. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**



Passengers board a CTA Green Line train Thursday at the Clinton station. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

RTA warns of 'doomsday' transit cuts if budget gap isn't plugged

In worst-case scenario, reductions could dramatically slash service across CTA, Metra and Pace

By Sarah Freishtat
Chicago Tribune

More than half of Chicago's bus routes could be eliminated, at least parts of four "L" lines could shut down and Metra weekday service would be slashed to once an hour under a transit doomsday scenario.

Those are some of the cuts under consideration if lawmakers fail to plug a \$771 million budget gap expected to hit the region's four transit agencies as soon as next year, when COVID-19 relief funding runs out, the Regional Transportation Authority said Friday. Also on the table are fare hikes and job losses.

The potential cuts represent a

worst-case scenario if none of the budget hole is filled. The reductions would dramatically slash service across the CTA, Metra and Pace, limit access to buses and trains across the city and suburbs and bring dire economic consequences to the region, the RTA warned.

"People have to understand what the consequences are of not filling the funding gap," said RTA Executive Director Leanne Redden, calling the effects of the potential cuts "devastating."

The agency outlined the situation as debate in Springfield heats up over the future of transit. Transit agencies and advocates have pushed to boost funding, while lawmakers have said their

focus is first on the way transit is overseen. Two bills under consideration by the General Assembly address oversight, with one calling to consolidate the CTA, Metra, Pace and the RTA into one entity, and another, backed by a coalition of labor groups, aiming to boost coordination among the existing agencies.

The RTA, for its part, has acknowledged that reform of transit is needed and supports measures similar to the labor-backed bill. Chairman Kirk Dillard has called for a stronger RTA that would coordinate fares, service and construction projects among city and suburban bus and train agencies. He has also proposed fare hikes, savings

from the new oversight model and more state funding to generate more money for transit.

But funding remains a pressing issue, RTA officials have said. They and other advocates have pushed to not just close the budget gap but go further and find \$1.5 billion in new money to overhaul the system.

With the extra money, transit could grow and efforts already underway could expand, like a CTA plan to run buses every 10 minutes on key routes or Metra's work to run more trains throughout the day rather than focusing on commuting hours, RTA officials said. CTA Acting President

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Trump calls for teardown of agency

Critics decry order aimed at Education Department's end

By Collin Binkley and Chris Megerian
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — President Donald Trump signed an executive order Thursday calling for the dismantling of the U.S. Education Department, advancing a campaign promise to take apart an agency that's been a longtime target of conservatives.

Trump has derided the Education Department as wasteful and polluted by liberal ideology. However, completing its dismantling is most likely impossible without an act of Congress, which created the department in 1979.

Republicans said they will introduce a bill to achieve that.

The department, however, is not set to close completely. The White House said the department will retain certain critical functions.

Trump said his administration will close the department beyond its "core necessities," preserving its responsibilities for Title I funding for low-income schools, Pell grants and money for children with disabilities. The White House said earlier it would also continue to manage federal student loans.

Trump blamed the department for America's lagging academic performance and said states will do a better job.

"It's doing us no good," he said at a White House ceremony.

Already, Trump's Republican administration has been gutting the agency. Its workforce is being slashed in half, and there have been deep cuts to the Office for Civil Rights and the Institute of Education Sciences, which gathers data on the nation's academic progress.

Advocates for public schools said eliminating the department would leave children behind in an American education system that is fundamentally unequal.

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INSIDE

'Every detail in the game matters'

For Illinois freshman guard Kasparas Jakucionis, his first — and perhaps only — NCAA Tournament is about "the beauty of basketball." **Chicago Sports**

Live-action film for apple of Disney's eye

"Snow White" is the latest in Disney's subset of animated musicals turned into live-action remakes. And despite a little blaat, it's one of the better ones. **A+E**



Aurora mayoral challenger John Laesch, left, and incumbent Richard Irvin shake hands after a March 10 mayoral forum at the Santori Public Library in Aurora. **MARK BLACK/FOR THE BEACON-NEWS**

Dems target Irvin as he seeks 3rd term as mayor of Aurora

Laesch gets aid from party in ostensibly nonpartisan election

By Christian Smith and Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

After making history in 2017 as Aurora's first Black mayor and cruising to reelection four years ago, Richard Irvin now faces a political challenge partly of his own making as he seeks a third term leading Illinois' second-largest city.

The ostensibly nonpartisan April 1 election is a rematch against John Laesch, an Aurora alderman at-large who was one of two candidates Irvin bested by more than 30 points in 2021. But this time Laesch is getting a boost from the Illinois Democratic Party, which entered the fray after Irvin repeatedly slammed Gov. JB Pritzker during the mayor's well-funded but ill-fated bid for the Republican nomination for governor in 2022.

In a city where two-thirds

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